

Philadelphia Science Museum Closes as Supporters Seek to Reopen It

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

A familiar place for Philadelphia families has closed its doors. The Academy of Natural Sciences Museum announced on September 1 that it would close at the end of the month. Many families came for one last visit before the September 30 closure.

The Academy was founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828. In 1868, it became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton. Visitors could also explore animal displays and see live animals.

Drexel University has been responsible for the Academy's **finances** since 2011. It said costs had risen and fewer people had visited since the pandemic. During the final weeks, however, crowds grew sharply.

Supporters organized marches and a **petition** with more than 114,000 signatures. The William Penn Foundation offered a year of **temporary** funding. Drexel said it was exploring that offer, but would need a lasting financial plan before considering reopening.

The Academy holds more than 19 million scientific **specimens**. These are samples, such as fossils and plants, that researchers study. Drexel said students and researchers would keep **access** to the collection. Public **access** remains unclear.

Philadelphia's city council also plans public **hearings** to examine the closure and possible solutions. Whether or when the museum will reopen remains uncertain.

Word Treasure

finances -- Money an organization has, receives and spends.

petition -- A written request that people sign to show support.

temporary -- Lasting for a limited time.

specimens -- Samples that scientists collect and study.

access -- The ability or permission to enter or use something.

hearings -- Meetings where officials listen to information and views.

Background you need

The Academy was founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828.
Scientific specimens include samples such as fossils and plants.

Break it down

Introduces the museum's closure and final family visits.
Describes the Academy's history and exhibits.
Explains Drexel's account of financial difficulties.
Reports supporters' efforts and the temporary funding offer.
Explains collection access and planned city hearings.

Why it matters

The closure affects a place where generations of children explored natural history. Access to the collection for the public and the museum's possible reopening remain uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. When did the museum close?

- ☐ (A) At the start of 2011.
- ☐ (B) At the end of 1868.
- ☐ (C) On September 1.
- ☐ (D) On September 30.

2. What did the Academy first display in 1868?

- ☐ (A) A collection of live animals.
- ☐ (B) A dinosaur skeleton.
- ☐ (C) A collection of animal paintings.
- ☐ (D) A display of plant samples.

3. What financial problem did Drexel describe?

- ☐ (A) Lower costs and larger crowds.
- ☐ (B) Lower costs and fewer visitors.
- ☐ (C) Higher costs and larger crowds.
- ☐ (D) Higher costs and fewer visitors.

4. What did the William Penn Foundation offer?

- ☐ (A) A year of free museum tickets.
- ☐ (B) A year of extra public hearings.
- ☐ (C) A year of temporary funding.
- ☐ (D) A year of traveling exhibits.

5. Who did Drexel say would keep access to the collection?

- ☐ (A) March organizers and visitors.
- ☐ (B) Students and researchers.
- ☐ (C) Tourists and local families.
- ☐ (D) Donors and petition signers.

6. What does Philadelphia's city council plan to do?

- ☐ (A) Organize new dinosaur displays.
- ☐ (B) Offer free tickets to visitors.
- ☐ (C) Hold hearings about the closure.
- ☐ (D) Move the collection to schools.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Drexel University: Drexel said costs had risen and attendance had fallen since the pandemic. It said a lasting financial plan was needed before considering reopening.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):